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Contemporary Encounters with Apophatic Theology: the Case of Emmanuel Levinas

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Of those places where mystical traditions of Christian thought have received a warm welcome, post-Heideggerian continental thought is perhaps the most surprising. One of the first of the post-Heideggerians to make this move, Jean-Luc Marion turns to mystical theology in two related works, *L'idole et la distance* (1977) and *Dieu sans l'être* (1982).¹ There, mystical theology, represented most especially by Pseudo-Dionysius and Gregory of Nyssa, proves integral to Marion's attempt to formulate a theological position that evades the reigning Heideggerian understanding of theology as part and parcel of an onto-theo-logically determined metaphysics. Going one step further, Marion argues that mystical theology, especially in its naming of a Good Beyond Being, would even exceed Heidegger's own step back from metaphysics in the direction of the thought of Being by inscribing Being, beings and the difference between them within the play of the Good.

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> Since it is the Cause of all beings we should posit and ascribe to it all the affirmations v

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1. _Good Beyond Being_. Insofar as responsibility describes the genesis of the subject prior to Dionysius, the relation between the Good and the self whose origin it marks is here described :

2. _Hierarchy and asymmetry_. The fact that the Good calls me before I am implies that the response is a way irreversible being affected of responsibility" (OB, 84). The irreversibility of responsibility

3. _Infinity and abandon of desire_. Always coming after its summons, the response of responsibility is an abandon in response to the summons of the hidden Good can be compared to the advice that Dionysius'

4. _Hyper-terms_. Insofar as the ethical relation is not to be described in terms of Being but in terms of the presence of the infinite is not only a figure of negative theology. All the negative attributes of the Good (OB, 12) or "what makes this more than a term of negative theology, is my responsibility for the other's passivity. This hyper-passivity is, according to Levinas, "a passivity prior to the passivity-activity alternative " (OB, 121). Like the hyper-terms used by the mystical mode of Dionysius'

5. _The saying of praise_. Just as redoubled negation and the hyper- terms in Dionysius suggest an apophantic function of language. He calls this form of language which signifies beyond the categorical, being, beyond true and non-true" (OB, 45). Neither true nor false, the signification of saying the Good in terms, lies beyond the categorical alternatives posed by logical signification. Levinas tells us

¹*L'idole et la distance* (Paris: Grasset, 1977) and *Dieu sans l'être* (Paris: Fayard, 1982) [English translation as *God Without Being*, (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1991)].

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> In the yearning through which it is, being finds itself oriented toward an end that is with

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Jeffrey L. Kosky received his Ph.D. from The University of Chicago. He has published articles in religious studies and philosophy, and his book *The Philosophy of Religion in Emmanuel Levinas* will appear from Indiana University Press in the spring of 2001. He is the translator of Jean-Luc Marion's *On Descartes' Metaphysical Prism: The Constitution and the Limits of Onto-theo-logy in Cartesian Thought* and is completing a translation of Marion's *Etant donn'e: Essai d'une ph'nom'nologie de la donation*. He has taught at Williams College and now lives in Chicago.

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